Drainage System Care Guide

At **Rain Drains**, we take pride in designing, installing, and maintaining the highest quality drainage systems in Coastal Virginia. Proper maintenance is vital to ensure long-term functionality and protect your property. Maintenance packages are also available for purchase through Rain Drains.

Maintenance Schedule Matrix

System Component	Frequency	Primary Care Action
Drainage System Piping	6 – 12 Months	Annual hydrojet flush & hose rinse
Catch Basins	Every 6 Months	Remove debris from basin & lid; rinse
Sump Pumps & Basins	Every 12 Months	Inspect rubber joints, float, & pump body
Pop-Up Emitters	Every 6 Months	Inspect lid for cracking; replace 3–5 yrs
Gutters & Downspouts	Every 12 Months	Clear shingle grit/leaves from downspouts
Pool System Connections	Every 12 Months	Check rubber joints & valves for leaks
French & Foundation Drains	12 Mos – 5 Yrs	Hydrojet flush; camera inspection every 5 yrs
Grass Seed Establishment	Daily (Weeks 1–3)	Light watering 2–3x daily; first cut at 3"–3.5"
Sod Care & Lawn Cutting	Daily (Weeks 1–2)	Deep soak daily; pull test before first mow

1. Drainage System Piping

6 – 12 Month Interval

Drainage piping naturally collects debris over time, including asphalt roofing shingle grit, fallen leaves, twigs, organic algae, and grass clippings. Accumulated debris restricts water flow and reduces overall system capacity during heavy rain events.

- **Hydrojet Flushing:** We recommend a professional hydrojet flush at least once annually. High-pressure water jets travel through the piping to blast away buildup and stuck debris from internal pipe walls.
- **Follow-Up Rinse:** Following a hydrojet cleaning, clear remaining light particles using a standard garden hose to keep lines running at maximum velocity.

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2. Systems with Catch Basins

6 Month Interval

Catch basins are designed to capture surface water while trapping heavy sediment and debris inside the basin vault before water enters the primary piping network. Regular cleaning is essential to prevent overflow back into surrounding turf.

- **Debris Removal:** Lift the top grate and clear out accumulated leaves and mud using a shop vacuum, small garden shovel, or gloved hand.
- **Grate Maintenance:** Dislodge debris stuck within the grate slots by gently tapping the grate against a flat, solid surface.
- **System Flushing:** Once cleared, flush the interior of the catch basin with a garden hose to verify clean discharge into downstream piping.

3. Systems with Sump Pumps and Basins

12 Month Interval

While sump pump systems are mostly self-draining, routine annual inspections prevent mechanical failure during severe storm conditions.

- **Fitting & Seal Check:** Inspect flexible rubber couplings and check valves for cracking, splitting, dry rot, or loose hose clamps.
- **Pump Mechanics:** Check the pump casing for cracks or debris obstructions. Ensure electrical power cords are free from fraying or pinches.
- **Float Switch Verification:** Manually lift the float switch to confirm the motor engages. Verify the resting water level remains comfortably below the highest activation point of the float switch.

4. Systems with Pop-Up Emitters

6 Month Interval

Pop-up emitters release water at the discharge point while keeping lawn debris out of the outlet when water is not flowing.

- **Semi-Annual Inspection:** Pull up gently on the green emitter lid every 6 months to remove trapped turf clippings or rocks underneath.
- **Lid Replacement Window:** UV sunlight exposure and impact from lawnmowers degrade plastic over time. Plan to replace emitter caps every 3 to 5 years.
- **Replacement Sizing:** Standard replacement caps can be found at Lowe's, Home Depot, or Amazon under the search term: *"3-inch & 4-inch Pop-up Drainage Emitter."*

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5. Gutters and Gutter Downspouts

12 Month Interval

Roof runoff carries heavy granular shingle debris and organic matter directly into your underground drainage network. Protecting the intake points is vital to long-term performance.

- **Gutter Protection:** Installing high-quality gutter guards or leaf screens significantly reduces large debris enter the system.
- **Downspout Cleanouts:** Even with screens, fine shingle grit passes into lower adapters. Disconnect downspout boots annually and clean out accumulated grit using a shop vacuum or gloved hand.

6. Pool System Connections

12 Month Interval

Drainage lines connected to pool deck drains or backwash outlets require special attention due to chemical exposure and pressure fluctuations.

- **Joint & Fitting Audits:** Check all multiport valve adapters, sight glass fittings, and backwash discharge lines for stress cracks, leaks, or loose seals.
- **Exposed Line Check:** Inspect above-ground PVC pipes for sun damage or impact cracks prior to peak swimming season.

7. French Drains & Foundation Drains

12 Mos – 5 Yr Interval

Subsurface perforated drains require ongoing maintenance to prevent soil siltation and root intrusion from clogging the surrounding aggregate envelope.

- **Annual Maintenance:** Perform an annual low-pressure hydrojet flush to clear settled sediment out of the bottom channel.
- **5-Year Camera Inspection:** Schedule a comprehensive sewer camera inspection with Rain Drains every 5 years to evaluate structural integrity, filter fabric condition, and identify root blockages.

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8. Grass Seed Installation & Establishment

Daily Care (Weeks 1 – 3)

Following drainage trenching or grading, establishing new grass seed restores your lawn's appearance and prevents soil erosion around drainage channels.

- **Watering Schedule:** Water lightly 2 to 3 times daily for 10–15 minutes per zone. Keep the top 1 inch of soil consistently moist until seeds germinate (7–14 days). Never allow new seed to dry out completely.
- **Reduce Volume:** Once seedlings reach 1 inch tall, reduce watering frequency to once daily, applying slightly more depth to encourage deep root growth.
- **Foot Traffic & Mowing:** Keep pets and foot traffic off seeded areas for at least 4 weeks. Wait to perform the first mow until grass reaches 3 to 3.5 inches in height, cutting no lower than 2.5 to 3 inches with sharp mower blades.

9. Sod Installation & Post-Care

Daily Care (Weeks 1 – 2)

New sod provides immediate erosion protection around fresh drainage installations, but requires diligent watering to root firmly into the underlying soil.

- **First 2 Weeks (Rooting Phase):** Water heavily immediately after installation so moisture penetrates through the sod slab and 2 inches into the soil below. Water deeply once daily early in the morning for the first 14 days.
- **Checking Soil Seams:** Lift a corner of a sod roll periodically. Soil under the sod should feel wet to the touch. Pay special attention to edges along concrete driveways or patios, which dry out faster.
- **Root Pull Test & First Cut:** After 10–14 days, gently tug on the sod. If you feel firm resistance, the roots have knitted into the soil. Once rooted, perform your first lawn cut. Set mower blades high (3 to 3.5 inches) and ensure blades are freshly sharpened to prevent pulling up unknitted rolls.

Questions About Your Installation or Maintenance? Rain Drains is dedicated to keeping your yard dry and restored. For maintenance packages, turf questions, or service scheduling, visit **raindrainsva.com** or call **757-807-0080**.

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